

Philadelphia's Academy of Natural Sciences Museum Closes as Supporters Seek Reopening

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-03 3 min read

A favorite place for Philadelphia families has closed its doors. The Academy of Natural Sciences Museum closed on September 30, 2026, after families crowded in for final visits.

The museum opened to the public in 1828. Its dinosaur skeleton displays have drawn children since 1868. Visitors could also explore animal displays, meet live animals and learn from museum educators.

Drexel University has been responsible for the Academy's finances since 2011. The university said costs rose and **attendance** fell after the pandemic. During the museum's last weeks, however, **attendance** jumped.

Supporters organized marches, rallies and a **petition** with more than 114,000 signatures. Former museum worker Isa Betancourt returned to Philadelphia to help the campaign.

Before the closing date, the William Penn Foundation offered one year of temporary **funding**. That would give people time to explore longer-lasting solutions. Drexel said it was considering working with the foundation, but reopening would need a plan for paying costs over time.

The Academy holds more than 19 million scientific **specimens**, or samples used for study. Drexel says students and researchers will keep access to the collection. Public access remains unclear.

Philadelphia's city council also plans public **hearings** to learn why the museum closed and what could help it reopen.

Word Treasure

attendance -- The number of people who visit or take part.

petition -- A written request that people sign to show support.

funding -- Money provided to support an activity or organization.

specimens -- Samples kept for study.

hearings -- Meetings where officials listen to information about an issue.

Background you need

Scientific specimens are samples used for study.

Temporary funding can give people time to work on a longer-lasting solution.

Break it down

Opens with the museum's closure and final family visits.

Describes its history and exhibits.

Explains Drexel's financial statement and supporters' campaign.

Introduces the temporary funding offer.

Ends with collection access and planned city hearings.

Why it matters

The closure affects a place where families learned about nature. Its future public access and a plan for reopening remain uncertain.

Test what you remember

1. When did the Academy of Natural Sciences Museum close?

- ☐ (A) September 1, 2026
- ☐ (B) September 30, 2026
- ☐ (C) October 30, 2026
- ☐ (D) October 1, 2026

2. What could visitors see at the museum?

- ☐ (A) Dinosaur skeletons and live animals
- ☐ (B) Trains and railway signals
- ☐ (C) Spacecraft and moon rocks
- ☐ (D) Paintings and pottery displays

3. What did Drexel say happened after the pandemic?

- ☐ (A) Costs and attendance both rose.
- ☐ (B) Costs fell and attendance rose.
- ☐ (C) Costs rose and attendance fell.
- ☐ (D) Costs and attendance both fell.

4. How did supporters show support for the museum?

- ☐ (A) By hosting classes and building exhibits
- ☐ (B) By holding races and selling tickets
- ☐ (C) By running tours and opening shops
- ☐ (D) By organizing marches and signing a petition

5. What did the William Penn Foundation offer?

- ☐ (A) One year of temporary funding
- ☐ (B) One year of new animal exhibits
- ☐ (C) One year of additional summer camps
- ☐ (D) One year of free school transport

6. Who does Drexel say will keep access to the collection?

- ☐ (A) Tourists and local shoppers
- ☐ (B) Students and researchers
- ☐ (C) Athletes and sports coaches
- ☐ (D) Artists and concert audiences

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: C 4: D 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Drexel University: Drexel said costs rose and attendance fell after the pandemic, and reopening would need a plan to pay costs over time.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):